He Never Expected Much

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He Never Expected Much

The poetry anthology for CIE IGCSE contains 15 poems. Below is a guide to Thomas Hardy's poem 'He Never Expected Much' from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1, Part 4 anthology. Below you will find:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line breakdown of the poem, including its possible meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods**: an exploration of the techniques and poetic choices that Hardy has used
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of the themes and ideas in the poem

Examiner Tips and Tricks

It is important to keep in mind that, while the poem will be printed on your exam paper, you are still expected to make reference to the poem and use accurate, relevant quotations to show your detailed understanding. Focus on the key words in the question and annotate the poem with the question in mind.

Be sure to structure your response clearly and write your analysis following the chronological order of the poem.

Overview

To help you answer the essay question on this poem, you will need to understand what it is about:

- The poem in a nutshell
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Hardy's intention and message

'He Never Expected Much' in a nutshell

'He Never Expected Much' by Thomas Hardy is a poem published in 1928, after the poet's death. It is written from the

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

"He Never Expected Much" breakdown

Lines 1–4

"Well, World, you have kept faith with me,

Kept faith with me;

Upon the whole you have proved to be

Much as you said you were."

Translation

- The speaker is talking to the world and declares that it has kept its promise

Hardy's intention

- The speaker directly addresses the world, personifying it as if it were capable of keeping faith or breaking it:
  - The technique of addressing something that is not alive is called **apostrophe**
- The phrase "kept faith with me" implies a sense of reliability on the part of the world and the technique of repeating the phrase immediately is also known as **epizeuxis**:
  - The repetition of the phrase emphasises the speaker's resignation that despite any hopes or expectations the speaker might have had, the world has simply remained true to its nature
- The line "much as you said you were" suggests that the world has lived up to its promises or descriptions and there's a sense of acknowledgement that the world has not deceived the speaker:
  - The world has been as it presented itself which could be seen as a validation of the world's predictability

Lines 5–8

"Since as a child I used to lie

Upon the leaze and watch the sky,

Never, I own, expected I

That life would all be fair."

Translation

- The speaker **reminisces** about his childhood

Hardy's intention

- The imagery of the speaker being a child evokes a sense of innocence and simplicity associated with childhood
- Despite the idyllic setting of the speaker's childhood, there's an understanding, even during his childhood, that life would not be "fair"
- The tone of the poem is one of reflective **realism**, as the speaker looks back on their past with a mixture of nostalgia and acceptance of life's disappointments

Lines 9–12

Help me understand

In that mysterious voice you shed

From clouds and hills around:"

Translation

- The speaker claims that the world spoke to him as a child

Hardy's intention

- The speaker personifies nature, attributing it the ability to speak through a "mysterious voice" emanating from "clouds and hills":
  - This suggests a close relationship between the speaker and the natural world
- The repetition of the phrase "since have said" underscores the significance of the message conveyed by nature:
  - It suggests that this communication is not a one-time occurrence but rather a recurring episode, which indicates a pattern in the speaker's interactions with the natural world
- The description of the voice as "mysterious" and the mention of "clouds and hills" as the sources of the mysterious voice reinforce the idea of nature as a powerful and **omnipresent** force:
  - Clouds and hills are symbolic of the vastness and grandeur of the natural landscape, suggesting that the messages conveyed by nature were filled with significance and wisdom

Lines 13–16

"'Many have loved me desperately,

Many with smooth serenity,

While some have shown contempt of me

Till they dropped underground."

Translation

- The speaker recounts what the world said to him when he was a child

Hardy's intention

- The world talks of people who "loved" it, and also those who have "shown contempt" of it:
  - However, all of these people have inevitably become a part of the earth
- The last line of stanza two serves as a reminder that death is **inevitable** and no matter how people live, they will end up "underground" after they die

Lines 17–20

"'I do not promise overmuch,

Child; overmuch;

Just neutral-tinted haps and such,'

You said to minds like mine."

child

Hardy's intention

- The phrase "I do not promise overmuch" implies a sense of moderation or caution in the assurances given by this higher power
- The use of the word "neutral-tinted" suggests a lack of vividness or intensity in the events that life may bring:
  - This indicates an acceptance of life's **inherent** uncertainties and the recognition that experiences may not always be extraordinary or remarkable
- The speaker's acknowledgement of their own limitations, expressed through the phrase "minds like mine" suggests a sense of humility and realism:
  - The speaker may recognise that they are not entitled to extravagant promises or assurances from the higher power
  - Instead, they are subject to the same "neutral-tinted occurrences" as everyone else

Lines 21–24

"Wise warning for your credit's sake!

Which I for one failed not to take,

And hence could stem such strain and ache

As each year might assign."

Translation

- The speaker talks about whether he took the world's advice or not

Hardy's intention

- The speaker acknowledges the value of a "wise warning" recognising it as a beneficial piece of advice
- The phrase "which I for one failed not to take" indicates that the speaker personally **heeded** the warning
- The line "and hence could stem such strain and ache" suggests that listening to the world's warning has enabled the speaker to endure the "strain and ache" of life's challenges:
  - This implies that the advice has equipped them with the resilience or coping mechanisms necessary to navigate difficult circumstances
- The phrase "as each year might assign" acknowledges the inevitability of facing various trials and tribulations each year:
  - This suggests an acceptance of life's unpredictability and the understanding that challenges are an inherent part of the human experience

Writer's methods

overall form of the poem; what comes at the beginning, middle and end of a poem) to **how** and **why** they have made the choices they have.

Focusing on the poet's overarching ideas, rather than individual poetic techniques, will gain you far more marks. Crucially, in the below sections, all analysis is arranged by theme, and includes Hardy's intentions behind his choices in terms of:

- **Form**
- **Structure**
- **Language**

Form

The poem is formed of three stanzas, which consist of eight lines each. These stanzas are also known as octaves.

Theme	**Evidence**	**Poet's intention**	
Realism	The metre varies with lines 1, 3 and lines 5–7 being **iambic tetrameter**, line 2 is **iambic dimeter** and lines 4 and 8 are **iambic trimeter**	The variation of the metre could reflect the trials and tribulations that life presents to people	

Structure

The poem consists of 24 lines, which are divided into three stanzas with a regular rhyme scheme.

Theme	**Evidence**	**Poet's intention**
Acceptance	The rhyme scheme of each of the stanzas is AAABCCCB with three consecutive lines rhyming together and the fourth and eighth line rhyming	The rhyme scheme adds a rhythmic element to the poem, much like a song or music. This could reflect the speaker's acceptance of life's "neutral-tinted haps"

	immediately and this technique is called epizeuxis. An example of this is in line 2, the phrase "Kept faith with me" is repeated	the monotony and repetitive nature of a life that has endured trials and tribulations rather than one filled with enjoyment

Language

The poem is written as a monologue spoken by a man who is elderly and reflecting on his life by talking to the world itself.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Acceptance	The writer uses **qualifiers** by inserting words and phrases like "upon the whole", "much as" and "I own"	The poet has done this so that the speaker appears vague when he talks about his experiences. This could suggest that life may not have been what he expected it to be, as the phrases suggest a resignation and acceptance for what he has experienced
	The writer has used an apostrophe in stanza one by addressing and speaking to the "World"	The use of an apostrophe at the beginning sets the tone of the poem and also indicates how the speaker is not expecting a response. It shows their acceptance of what they have experienced in their life as they look back and reflect

Understanding the text

It is not enough to just know the poem really well as all questions in the IGCSE encourage an informed, personal response. Therefore, you need to develop a solid understanding of the theme, main ideas, settings, situations and events depicted. Even though context is not explicitly assessed in the IGCSE, it is important that you have an awareness of background information that is relevant to the main themes in the poem as this can help you develop a sustained, critical understanding of the text. This is so that you are able to demonstrate individuality and insight in your answer. To help you do this, the section below has been divided into two main themes that Hardy explores in 'He Never Expected Much':

- Realism

- Thomas Hardy wrote 'He Never Expected Much' less than a year before his death in 1928 at the age of 87
- The poem is written from the **perspective** of someone who is looking back and thinking about how they lived an unremarkable life:
  - However, it is worth noting that the speaker assesses his life **stoically** and does not feel disappointed over how it turned out

- The poet uses phrases such as "upon the whole", "much as you said" and "neutral-tinted haps" to highlight how the speaker has a realistic view of his life that is neither positive nor negative
- The poem refers to his childhood and how he used to "watch the sky", declaring that he knew then that life would not "all be fair":
  - This suggests that the speaker did not focus on dreams or aspirations but instead had a realistic view that life might be difficult

Acceptance

- The poem's title gives the reader an insight into the speaker's outlook on life and the poem expands on that:
  - The phrase "he never expected much" highlights how the speaker may have had hopes and dreams but has also accepted the "World's" advice that "neutral-tinted haps" should be good enough for the speaker

- However, in the second stanza, the poet writes from the perspective of the "World" and declares that everyone dies and is buried, irrespective of the lives they lived:
  - Therefore, it could be argued that the speaker has spared himself by taking the advice and therefore being able to "stem such strain and ache"

- The poem's underlying message is that, despite what people may think, no one has control over their own lives and instead the "mysterious voice" among the "clouds and hills around" is in control:
  - The speaker in the poem has accepted this and has therefore lived a life with stoic optimism

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